HCP 1825: a Pigpen postcard signed Mary

Origin and context

HC Portal record **1825**, catalogue name **pc_hcp_506**, preserves two watermarked scans of a private-collection postcard. It is distinct from portal record 506. The source is https://crypto.hcportal.eu/dashboard/cryptograms/1825 . All three rendered tabs were inspected on 26 October 2026: status Not solved, Pigpen tag, category Substitution / Monoalphabetic, unknown language and date. Neither a transcription nor a solution was attached.

The address-side scan bears the cleartext opening “Both puzzles correct” and eight rows of Pigpen. The address reads Miss Stirling, Islay House Square, Bridgend, Islay. The picture caption is “Kilbarchan from the Public park”; no cipher appears there. The postmark date cannot securely be read. The card's writer signs Mary; no fuller identity is established. The message concerns the recipient's health, wet weather and marriages.

The alternating dotted/undotted Pigpen alphabet was transferred from prior internal work on HCP1187/1188, rather than fitted word by word. It accounts for all **95 letter signs**, with 21 distinct signs used. The independent reviewer, Claude Opus 5.5, returned REVISE on 26 October 2026: the body and key were correct, while three transcription errors and punctuation/source-record details needed correction. Every finding is addressed below; the reviewer explicitly required no further round after those corrections.

Literal decoded text

```
I HOPE YOU ARE
A GOOD DEAL BETTER.
WHAT KIND OF
WEATHER ARE YOW
GETTING? VERY
WET HERE ANY
MORE MARRIAGES?
KIND LIVE MARY.
```

The unencrypted opening **Both puzzles correct** is source cleartext, not claimed as deciphered. Source comma marks separating words are rendered as spaces. The full stops after BETTER and MARY and the question marks after GETTING and MARRIAGES are present in the handwriting.

Normalized reading and Slovak translation

“I hope you are a good deal better. What kind of weather are you getting? Very wet here. Any more marriages? Kind love, Mary.”

„Dúfam, že sa máš oveľa lepšie. Aké máte počasie? Tu je veľmi mokro. Nejaké ďalšie sobáše? So srdečnou láskou, Mary.“

This normalizes exactly two literal anomalies: **YOW → YOU** and **LIVE → LOVE**, one glyph each. In the literal original, YOW is the spelling in the second YOU position and LIVE the closing word. Those substitutions are the writer's apparent slips, not changes to the key. The translation conveys their likely intended meaning. Mary is the signature read from the cipher; her historical identity is unknown. The cleartext opening means „Obe hádanky sú správne.“

Key

Pigpen with alternating undotted/dotted letters, transferred unchanged from the earlier HCP1188/HCP1187 work. The portal already labels the cipher family. Short internal dashes serve as the writer's dots.

Visible outline	Token	Undotted	Dotted
bottom/right	BR	A	B

Visible outline	Token	Undotted	Dotted
bottom/left/right	B	C	D
bottom/left	BL	E	F
top/bottom/right	R	G	H
four sides	C	I	J
top/bottom/left	L	K	L
top/right	TR	M	N
top/left/right	T	O	P
top/left	TL	Q	R
downward V	V	S	T
right-pointing wedge	>	U	V
left-pointing wedge	<	W	X
upward wedge	^	Y	Z

Transcription tokens append 0 for undotted and 1 for dotted. The complete 95-sign transcript uses 21 distinct signs; no sign requires two values.

Reproduce

From repository root:

```
python3 -I ciphers/hcp-1825/work/decode.py
```

The command checks preserved source hashes and decodes the manual outline/dot transcription in work/. The portal supplied no transcription. It does not OCR the scan; exact token roundtrip checks internal consistency, not independent pixel verification. The independent review collated all signs against the scan and decoded them using a separate implementation in review/work/review_decode.py. After the corrections, the two complete 95-sign readings agree.

Evidence and limits

One unchanged alphabet yields coherent English across all eight lines. The signature's touching M and A have the same separate outlines as MA in MARRIAGES. The second word YOU has a left-pointing final wedge, unlike the right-pointing wedge in the first YOU. The closing V has an internal dash-dot, while its I is a genuinely closed box; hence literal YOW and LIVE remain in the decoder output. The likely YOU and LOVE are explicit interpretations. A dot at the baseline between M and O in MORE is outside the M outline and is treated as a pen touch, rather than an internal dot that would give NORE. These are disclosed source features, not word-wise key exceptions.

The source date is unreadable and the catalogue gives none. The address reads Miss Stirling, Islay House Square, Bridgend, Islay; the catalogue spelling is Stioling. The identities of Mary and Miss Stirling and whether they regularly exchanged puzzles are unestablished. Both scans have a large watermark. The 110-record register snapshot has no matching URL or name; that does not prove historical priority. No published target plaintext was used.

Response to review 1

1. **Signature (major): corrected CRY to MARY.** The first apparent closed-bottom outline is actually two touching signs, TR0 BR0. The top bar projects left of the first upright, as in the MA of MARRIAGES (review crops z8-mary.png and z7-ma.png). Updated transcript, literal text, translation, signature discussion and count from 94 to 95.
2. **Closing V (major transcription): corrected LIUE to LIVE.** The rightward wedge contains a clear dash-dot (z8-love.png), matching V in VERY. The closed box remains I. Intended LOVE therefore requires one source-sign correction, not two. Removed the obsolete argument.

3. **Second YOU (major transcription): corrected to literal YOW.** Its last wedge points left (z4-you.png), matching the W that opens WEATHER; the earlier YOU ends with a right wedge (z1-you.png). Normalized YOU is now explicitly separate from the literal output.
4. **Punctuation after GETTING (minor): retained source question mark.** The heavy hook and lower dash match the mark after MARRIAGES (z5-q.png). Replaced the earlier unresolved-overwriting account.
5. **Mark after M in MORE (minor): disclosed baseline pen touch.** It sits outside the TR outline and near O's foot, unlike internal mid-height dots (z7-more.png). M is retained; interpreting it as N would give NORE. The visual basis is primary; English is supporting.
6. **Record keeping and punctuation (minor): corrected the address to Islay House Square in SOURCES.md without editing immutable metadata.** Also restored the source full stop after BETTER; the closing stop and both question marks are literal. Word-separator commas are explicitly rendered as spaces; normalized sentence punctuation is distinguished.

All six findings are addressed. Corrections concern transcription and source record keeping; the key and method have not changed. The reviewer explicitly stated that these corrections do not require another round.